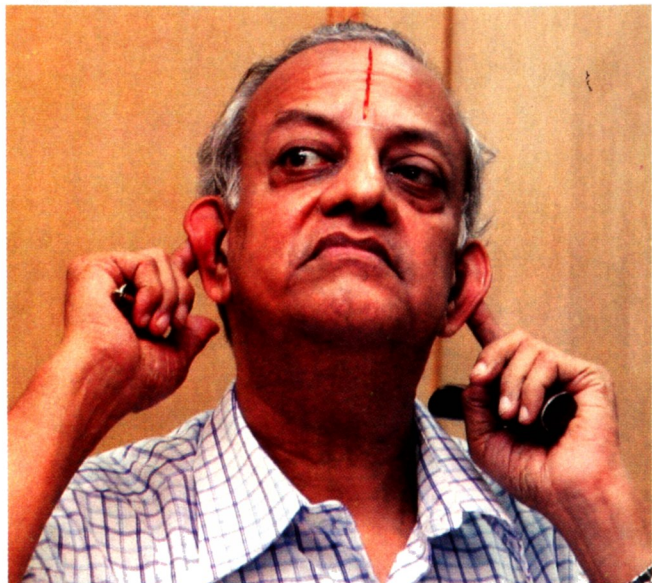


PARVEEN NEGI



Poll-arised Panel

DELHI The Election Commission (EC) announced dates for Assembly elections in five states—Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Mizoram and Delhi—but shied away from announcing polls in Jammu and Kashmir. Even as the BJP termed the exclusion of J&K from poll process as “intriguing”, the Congress conveniently said that it was the EC’s prerogative

and decision.

The EC, however, was itself in a dilemma. Sources claimed that Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) N. Gopalaswami and his deputies Naveen Chawla and S.Y. Quraishi had major differences of opinion which couldn’t be ironed out.

For the record, Gopalaswami said that they were still assessing the situation and would announce poll dates for

BUYING TIME: Gopalaswami

J&K soon. It came as a surprise to the other commissioners when the CEC himself objected to early polls. For the time being they did not want to make the split verdict public and preferred to wait for some time.

“Governor’s rule in the state is expiring on January 10, 2009. So the EC still has some time to iron out their differences,” said a senior official.

Another issue was the availability of security forces. At a meeting on October 10, Home Secretary Madhukar Gupta told Gopalaswami that they were not in a position to spare 800 companies of security personnel required to ensure peaceful, free and fair elections in the state. He made it clear that it would be extremely difficult to hold polls in J&K along with other states since they too require heavy security deployment. The EC is clearly buying time to sort out its differences.

by Bhavna Vij-Aurora

SIGNPOSTS

ARRESTED: Subrata Bayen alias Fateh Ali by the Kolkata Police. He was on the Interpol’s Most Wanted list for funding terror groups, arms dealing and a grenade attack on Awami League leader Sheikh Hasina in Dhaka which took 24 lives.



AWARDED: To music conductor Zubin Mehta, Japan’s Praemium Imperiale

award, a ¥15 million (Rs 69 lakh) global arts prize instituted by the Japan Art Association.

WON: By Jwala Gutta and V. Diju, the women’s doubles and mixed doubles titles at the Bulgarian Grand Prix badminton tournament in Sofia. They won their consecutive doubles Grand Prix title. Gutta and Shruti Kurian won the mixed doubles.

WON: By Chitra Magimairaj, the Australian Open Women’s Snooker Championship in Sydney.

VIS-A-VIS MANMOHAN SINGH prime minister versus MIRWAIZ UMAR FAROOQ Hurriyat Conference chairman

“
Kashmir is a part of India. Talks with separatists can be held bilaterally, not via tripartite process involving Pakistan.
”



SAURABH SINGH

“
Kashmir is disputed and has to be resolved through tripartite talks only and not through bilateral dialogue.
”

EPILOGUE: Double-take or triple whammy, Kashmir remains the number one talking shop.